



In the Name of RELIGION

Violence in Punjab over the Vienna killings gives a global dimension to India's caste divisions

| By Arvind Chhabra |

It doesn't take a lot to rouse communal passions in the country. Even prosperous and seemingly peaceful Punjab erupted in caste violence overnight. Days of violence, following the fatal attack on Dera Sach Khand Ballan leaders in Vienna took the lives of three people. Scores of vehicles and trains were torched and

public property worth crores was damaged. Curfew was imposed and despite the massive security forces, and appeals by Dera leaders, it took days to restore normalcy.

Though many are baffled over the scale of violence that erupted, people here have not been taken by surprise. "It is understandable, a spontaneous outburst," said Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal, as the violence erupted

within hours of the attack on Sant Niranjan Dass and Sant Ramanand, leading to the death of the latter.

Dera-related violence has ceased to surprise people in Punjab. Earlier, it was Sirsa-based Dera Sacha Sauda's followers who have been part of clashes and before that it was Baba Piara Singh Bhaniarewala's followers. But in both these cases, radical Sikhs had found "clear provocations", while in the case of Dera Sach Khand, nothing of that sort is apparent.

Situated in the village of Ballan—seven miles north of Jalandhar, on the Pathankot road—the Dera peacefully propagates the preachings of its guru, Ravidass. Actually, this is where the tiff starts—the difference in the doctrines between the Sikhs and the Ravidassias. "Dera Ballan became a paragon of the Ravidass movement in north-west India and it made concerted efforts for the construction of a separate Dalit